opened, like thousands of others, my 82-year-old mother and I went on 11 November to the nearest bank, to join the queues to exchange our money into usable currency, for our upcoming pilgrimage. Our auto driver said that he'd never felt so poor. *'Didi, mere paas 5,000 rupiye they, par mujhe do din bhuka sona pada.'* He had ₹5,000 in cash but had to sleep hungry for two nights as banks and ATMs had neither started exchanging notes nor dispensing the 'new' cash and no one was willing to accept the now worthless old notes.

As per RBI instructions, banks had remained closed on 9 November and ATMs on both 9 and 10 November to help bank staff gear up for the tsunami of cash deposits and withdrawals that was about to hit them. As the nation scrambled to obtain cash, serpentine queues formed outside every bank in the country. Bankers did their best to cope, but were often flummoxed by the frequently changing rules and guidelines. Between 8 November and 30 December, no less than 63 circulars pertaining to the note ban were issued by RBI. These circulars, which refer to demonetization as 'Withdrawal of Legal Tender Character of existing ₹500/- and ₹1,000/- Bank Notes' (or Specified Bank Notes – SBNs) are fascinating for the picture they present of the muddled and confused implementation of the note ban.

As the queues lengthened and the chaos continued, it became painfully clear that no one was in charge. The RBI Governor Urjit Patel was conspicuous by his silence, as were Finance Minister Arun Jaitley, the Chief Economic Advisor Arvind Subramanian, and the NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Arvind Panagariya.

Whether by design or happenstance, the RBI issued ₹2,000 notes before they started the real remonetization. This caused much controversy and some embarrassment to the government. On the one hand, the objective of demonetization was stated to be the removal of black money held as cash. On the other, the ₹2,000 notes released, because they were of the higher denomination, made stashing and caching money easier for black money hoarders, while making life